

Supplemental Materials: Party or Climate? The Polarization of the US Public's Energy Preferences

Methods

Survey Sample

Respondents were recruited from Cloud Research, a survey panel provider that uses a variety of online recruitment methods to build a large and diverse panel of respondents. Cloud Research provides a quota-based sampling approach, where US Census data is used to ensure representation across key demographic groups. The survey was internet based, and administered in QuestionPro. It was fielded from April 10 to April 15, 2026.

Despite the use of quotas, the sample is not perfectly representative of the US population. Specifically, the sample was slightly younger, whiter, more educated, and more aligned with the Democratic party than the US population. To address this, I used the `survey` and `anesrake` packages in R to perform iterative raking to compute survey weights that align the sample with the US Census's 2023 American Community Survey (ACS) on key demographic variables, including age, race, gender, and education. Additionally, I used the Pew Research Center's National Public Opinion Reference Survey (NPORS) from 2025 to align the sample on political party affiliation.¹ The differences between the unweighted and weighted sample are shown in Table 1. The weights were then applied to all analyses in the paper.

Table 1: Unweighted vs. Weighted Means on Key Variables

	Unweighted	Weighted	Difference
Age (years)	43.624	47.287	3.662
Male	0.489	0.472	-0.016
White (non-Hispanic)	0.677	0.599	-0.077

¹See here: <https://www.pewresearch.org/politics/fact-sheet/party-affiliation-fact-sheet-npors/>.

	Unweighted	Weighted	Difference
College graduate	0.556	0.362	-0.194
Democrat	0.563	0.450	-0.113
Republican	0.287	0.460	0.173

Note: Weights computed via iterative raking to ACS 2023 and Pew NPORS targets.

Covariate Balance Across Conditions

Respondents were randomly assigned to the Trump cue, climate cue, or control condition. Table 2 compares covariates across the three conditions to confirm that random assignment produced comparable groups. Of the covariates examined, the conditions differ significantly only on age and the share of white respondents; the pre-treatment political-beliefs moderators (liberal Democrats and conservative Republicans) are balanced across conditions.

Table 2: Covariate Balance Across Experimental Conditions

Variable	Control	Climate	Trump	p-value
Age (years)	42.63	44.51	43.76	0.019
Male	49.1%	49.2%	48.3%	0.915
White (non-Hispanic)	69.5%	63.5%	70.0%	0.002
Education (1–8)	4.07	4.03	4.03	0.793
Income (1–11)	4.71	4.61	4.55	0.415
College graduate	56.1%	54.7%	56.0%	0.772
Democrat	54.7%	55.8%	58.4%	0.208
Republican	29.5%	29.3%	27.4%	0.488
Liberal Democrat	45.7%	47.6%	49.8%	0.171
Conservative Republican	25.3%	25.6%	22.5%	0.195

Note: Cell entries are unweighted condition means: percentages for binary indicators and means for continuous measures. The p-value tests for differences across the three conditions (chi-square for indicators, one-way ANOVA for continuous measures); non-significant values indicate the covariate is balanced across conditions, as expected under random assignment.

Robustness: Controlling for Demographic Covariates

Because the conditions differ by chance on age and race (see Table 2), I re-estimate the main difference-in-differences models adding age, sex, race, education, and income as additive controls. Table 3 reports the same contrasts as the main-text difference-in-differences table. The estimated treatment effects on the partisan gap are substantively unchanged from the main specification, indicating that the cue effects are not driven by the chance covariate imbalances across conditions.

Table 3: Difference-in-Differences Estimates with Demographic Controls

Contrast	Fossil Fuels	Wind	Solar	Hydro	Nuclear
Omnibus F-test (any treatment effect on gap)	F = 4.03*	F = 0.78	F = 0.50	F = 1.81	F = 1.17
Climate Cue vs Control	-2.45 [-7.02, 2.13]	0.04 [-3.13, 3.21]	0.90 [-2.46, 4.26]	2.19† [-0.17, 4.55]	-0.69 [-5.08, 3.70]
Trump Cue vs Control	-7.43** [-12.56, -2.29]	1.60 [-1.30, 4.50]	1.72 [-1.65, 5.09]	1.64 [-0.68, 3.96]	2.47 [-1.66, 6.60]
Trump Cue vs Climate	-4.98† [-10.23, 0.27]	1.56 [-1.44, 4.55]	0.81 [-2.47, 4.10]	-0.55 [-2.89, 1.78]	3.16 [-1.22, 7.55]

*Note: Replicates the difference-in-differences table from the main text, adding age, sex, race, education, and income as additive controls to each svyglm model. The top row shows the omnibus F-test for whether treatments jointly shift the partisan gap on each energy source; subsequent rows show the estimated change in the partisan gap (Liberal Democrats – Conservative Republicans) when moving from one condition to another, with 95% confidence intervals in brackets. Positive values indicate the gap widened. Estimates use survey weights; standard errors and confidence intervals are design-based. *** $p < 0.001$, ** $p < 0.01$, * $p < 0.05$, † $p < 0.10$.*

Pairwise Differences in the Preferred Energy Mix

Table 4 reports design-based tests of the differences in the predicted preferred energy mix shown in the main text. The partisan-gap rows test the difference between liberal Democrats and conservative Republicans within each condition; the within-party rows test whether each party's preferred share shifts across conditions. The partisan gaps are significant for every source and condition, whereas the within-party cue effects are concentrated among conservative Republicans in the Trump condition.

Table 4: Pairwise Differences in the Predicted Preferred Energy Mix

Comparison	Fossil Fuels	Wind	Solar	Hydro	Nuclear
Gap (Dem - Rep): Control	-16.1***	10.9***	10.0***	2.0*	-6.7***
Gap (Dem - Rep): Climate	-18.1***	11.0***	11.0***	4.1***	-8.1***

Comparison	Fossil Fuels	Wind	Solar	Hydro	Nuclear
Gap (Dem - Rep): Trump	-23.5***	12.4***	11.6***	3.7***	-4.3**
Republicans: Climate - Control	0.2	0.7	-1.2	-0.6	0.9
Republicans: Trump - Control	9.5***	-2.4*	-3.4*	-1.6†	-2.2
Republicans: Trump - Climate	9.4***	-3.1*	-2.2	-1.0	-3.1
Democrats: Climate - Control	-1.8	0.9	-0.2	1.6*	-0.4
Democrats: Trump - Control	2.2†	-0.9	-1.7†	0.1	0.3
Democrats: Trump - Climate	4.0***	-1.8†	-1.5	-1.4*	0.7

*Note: Cell entries are estimated differences in the predicted preferred share (percentage points) underlying Figure 2. Partisan-gap rows are the Liberal Democrats – Conservative Republicans difference within each condition; within-party rows are the change for that party when moving from one condition to another (positive = the later condition is higher). Estimates use survey weights; standard errors and p-values are design-based. *** $p < 0.001$, ** $p < 0.01$, * $p < 0.05$, † $p < 0.10$.*

Survey Question Wording

Trump cue: As you may have heard, the Trump administration has taken steps to increase the production of fossil fuels, particularly coal, and reduce the use of renewable energy like solar and wind for electricity generation.

Using a scale of 1 to 5, where 1 means strongly oppose and 5 means strongly support, how do you feel about the Trump administration's goal of increasing the use of fossil fuels and decreasing the use of renewable sources in generating electricity?

Climate cue: Scientists agree that the use of fossil fuels has contributed to climate change, and to address climate change, we need to increase the use of renewable sources such as wind, solar, and hydropower.

Using a scale of 1 to 5, where 1 means strongly disagree and 5 means strongly agree, how do you feel about increasing the use of renewable sources in generating electricity as a way to address climate change?

Thinking about the overall supply of electricity. What percentage of the total U.S. electricity supply over the next 20 years would you like to see come from each of the 5 primary sources?

NOTE: The sum of the five boxes below must equal 100

Fossil fuels (coal, oil, natural gas), which produced 58 percent in 2024 Wind energy, which produced 10 percent in 2024 Solar energy, which produced 7 percent in 2024 Hydropower, which produced 5 percent in 2024 Nuclear energy, which produced 18 percent in 2024

Additional Hypotheses

In addition to the hypotheses present in the paper, I also preregistered other hypotheses that were not included in the paper. These include hypotheses about the effects of political beliefs on support/opposition to the climate change and Trump cues, as well as hypotheses about how the general impacts of the climate change and Trump cues, regardless of political ideology.

CUES Conservative Republicans will be more supportive of Trump's actions to increase the use of fossil fuels and decrease the use of renewable sources than those with other political beliefs

Liberal Democrats will be more supportive of increasing the use of renewable sources to address climate change than those with other political beliefs

ENERGY MIX Those who receive the Trump cue will support a higher percentage of fossil fuels than those in the climate change or control group

Those who receive the climate cue will support a higher percentage of renewable energy sources (wind, solar, hydropower) than those in the Trump or control group